later merged with the Jatiyatabadi Front in May 1978 with Ziaur Rahman as its leader. In September, the same year, all the fledgling political fronts close to Zia were dissolved and the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) was born. The BNP swept the February 1979 election, winning two hundred and seven out of three hundred seats. The CIA, in a report, said that Zia had moved further away from India and the Soviet Union while deepening ties with the USA and China. The only solace for India was that Mohammed Ershad was head of the Bangladeshi army.

Raja Man Singh said that as a politician who tried to transform himself into a mass leader in the mould of Sheikh Mujib, Ziaur Rahman was a complete failure. When Indira Gandhi returned to power in early 1980, India tried to help Zia establish the rule of law and true democracy in Bangladesh, but he was suspicious of India's friendly overtures.

'His military approach in dealing with public issues and his ruthlessness towards army colleagues weakened his position. There was simmering anger in the army and we knew it was just a matter of time before another quake struck Bangladesh. We patiently waited for it/ Raja Man Singh told me.

On 30 May 1981, Ziaur Rahman was assassinated by a group of army officers in Chittagong. The development shocked China, the USA and close Islamic allies of Bangladesh, but according to Singh, India was not surprised.

'The BNP and its supporters had turned corrupt and were radicalised in a very short span of time. There was no space for secularism in Bangladesh under Zia and a group within the army that had fought for liberation was disenchanted with his rule/ Raja Man Singh said.